

HYDERABAD BLASTS, AUGUST 26, 2007

There is an urgent need to build a national identity card system to track illegal immigrants and possible terror suspects

and thwart them. Doval says, "When you reform, you only look at past mistakes. When you transform, you ready for future threats."

That means assessing the terrorists' capabilities and then proactively working to defang them before they can strike. The major threat continues to come from Pakistan-backed groups like the Lashkar-e-Toiba and the Jaish-e-Mohammed and from the Bangladesh-based Harkat-ul-Jihad Islami, which allegedly has close linkages with the Student Islamic Movement of India.

Infiltration of terrorists from across the border, which had come down in the past few years, is showing an upswing again. "The Pakistan-based handlers of terror groups operating in Kashmir are getting desperate to replenish the depleted ranks of terrorists before the crucial Assembly elections later this year," says Kuldeep Khoda, DGP, Jammu and Kashmir. Last year top Hizbul and Lashkar operatives as well as Safdar Nagori, the head of SIMI, were arrested, giving security agencies a major boost.

The assessment, though, is that the new Pakistani government will not be any different from previous ones, given the recent statements by the new Pakistani Prime Minister Yusuf Raza Gilani and Pakistan's Army Chief Ashraf Kiyani that moral, diplomatic and political support to the Kashmir issue will continue, which is a new euphemism for jihad in Kashmir. "It is a weak government in Pakistan. At the political level there is little inclination to act against these terrorist groups, and ISI is making full use of it. The epicentre of terrorism will continue to remain in Pakistan," says G. Parthasarathy, former Indian high-commissioner to Pakistan.

To ensure more effective co-ordination between the Centre and the states in combating terrorism, the Centre has wrestled with creating a federal investigation agency (FIA) along the lines of FBI to investigate federal crimes like terrorism. What is needed is an FIA or Central law enforcement agency that not only takes suo-moto action in case of a terror strike but also collects intelligence and coordinates with the various state police agencies. It is not going to be easy to push through. Gupta confesses, "It is difficult to build a consensus because police and crime are a state subject and it may mean over-reaching the constitutional jurisdiction of the states." Nikhil Kumar, MP and former special secretary, internal security,

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adds, "The opposition by some states is based on a mistaken notion that it will be used by the Centre to encroach upon their turf. However, FIA will take suo-moto action only in a limited number of cases."

There is also an urgent need to beef up technical intelligence capabilities, whether it be using satellites for communication intercepts or beefing up immigration checks at airports and better surveillance to check infiltration. As essential is the need to build a national identity cards system to check illegal immigration. Apart from that a national database for criminals would help states coordinate their counter-terror activities.

With terrorists concentrating their strikes on busy shopping areas to get maximum casualties, the Union Home Ministry is working on security benchmarking requirements for shopping areas that have heavy footfalls. These would include mandatory installation of internal surveillance systems like close-circuit TV, apart from access control mechanisms. Says Gupta, "We are working on a multi-faceted approach to combat terror because the challenges keep growing as does the complexity." In all this, speed of implementation is the key. Unfortunately it is missing.

**with Ramesh Vinayak, Saurabh Shukla,
Amarnath K. Menon and Rohit Parihar**